Trade Today For Tomorrow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48181666.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warning:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationship:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	Immortality, Reincarnation, Modern AU but still Canon Species, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Getting Back Together, Growing Up Together, Not Really Character Death, Implied Sexual Content, ex-wives, I promise I fix that, star-crossed lovers, One Shot, don’t look at the series header it’s a liar, POV Alternating, I didn't use archive warnings because I wasn't sure if temporary character death counted lol
Language:	English
Series:	Part 1 of Love You Until The Day I Die (And Then Do It Again)
Collections:	Catradora AUs by n7punk
Stats:	Published: 2023-06-27 Words: 18,692 Chapters: 1/1

Trade Today For Tomorrow

by n7punk

Summary

Grief is the only thing that can kill an immortal, but it's going to take Catra down long before old age can get to her mortal genes. It's hard loving Adora. It's even harder knowing that no matter how Adora feels now, one day Catra is going to be gone but Adora won't. She'll move on, she'll forget, or Catra will be her death sentence. Every one of their days together carries the silent weight of death with it.
She can't take it. She leaves. The sorrow in their every interaction hurts her too much. She would rather be forgotten now than ruin the rest of their lives. She doesn't want Adora to know the moment she dies. Better heartbroken than mourning. When her life turns out to be short, it feels like vindication.
At least until she blinks her eyes open again.
(Immortal lover/Reincarnation AU)

Notes

IT'S REINAEIRY'S FAULT. The song is about her OCs but it got the horrible evil little gears in my head spinning and now we're here. I've always said this kind of AU is way too depressing for me to do, and this is gonna be Heavy, but hopefully with enough of a happy ending.
Content warnings: listen, you clicked this so you know what you're in for, but suicide will be referenced in addition to general themes of death, depression, panic attacks, and feelings of choking (not *being* choked, to be clear, we're talking panic attack-type stuff).

See the end of the work for more notes

It’s not a love story that’s meant to be, Catra knows that from age eight when she learns about death and mortality.

Namely, that she has it and her best friend doesn’t.

Catra is lying upside down, head hanging off the bed that she shares with Adora at the orphanage, while Adora quietly tells a story about her parents. She doesn’t remember much about them, only a few years old when her mortal father died and the weight of his loss took her mother with him, but Adora likes to talk about them to remember. Her mother had lived so long that she had no one left but her husband. Adora doesn’t know why her dad didn’t have family to take her in, just that she ended up here, with Catra.

Adora is immortal just like her mother. It’s not guaranteed to pass down, but the unnatural blue of her eyes and the way they glow softly along with her hair in moonlight makes it clear. It’s a fact Catra has always known, just like she has always known that she’s just a regular magicat, but she never thinks much of it until Adora says it.

“Grief is the only thing that could have killed Mom.”

Marlena was immortal. Nothing else could have taken her down. Nothing else could take *Adora* down. Perfect, kind, loving Adora. The only person in the whole home, seemingly in the whole *town*, who gives a shit about Catra.

And she’s going to live forever, while Catra fades into distant memory.

Loss landed them where they are now, but that day is the first when Catra really understands death.

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The weight of forever always seemed like a curse to Adora. Maybe because she grew up in such a rough home and her only concept of life was a painful one, but she never got a period of childhood innocence when she considered her long life a gift. Immortals have been worshipped as gods in the past, but now they’re just the privileged. The wealthy, or even the royal, but Adora only remembers being an orphan.

In the dark of the orphanage, Catra makes her happy even when she’s crying. Catra talks about the future like there’s one out there that’s worth chasing. Catra becomes her family when she has no one else. Catra cares about her and tries to defend her even when she doesn’t need it or no one else would dare try. Catra is the bravest soul Adora has ever met. Catra is her *everything*.

She doesn’t think about the fact Catra’s mortal like all the rest of the kids. One day, she’ll be gone, but Adora has never wanted forever anyway. She doesn’t find joy in it. She finds joy in

sneaking up onto the roof and twining her fingers with Catra's, giggling in the dark of night. The gentle glow from Adora's hair is just enough for Adora to see when they're under the stars, but when they sneak back through the hallways and there is no moonlight to guide them, Catra leads them both with her superior vision. Adora takes her hand and implicitly trusts her to take her exactly where she needs to be.

To Adora, Catra has always seemed more extraordinary than she is. She would move the moons and stars for her. Whatever future there is for Adora, it's with Catra. She knows what she is, but as a young girl she sets it aside and never thinks of it again. She has Catra. That's all she needs.

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Catra has always been in love with Adora. She kissed her for the first time when they were just kids, but the first time it matters, they're both seventeen. There have been four kisses over the years, each carefully marked and held close to Catra's heart, but this is the one where Adora pulls away, staring down at her with starstruck eyes, and whispers *wow*.

This is the first one where it means the same thing to Adora as it did to Catra, where she finally pulls her head out of the clouds and realizes they're on a clock. Adora can take forever to turn Catra's way, but Catra only has so long.

Even the thought of Adora one day moving on hurts, but Adora has always been her only source of happiness, so she clings to her desperately. They have too much to worry about. The orphanage madame doesn't like anyone dragging Adora's *potential* down and she especially hates Catra. They have to sneak around, and then they have a future to worry about when they're eighteen and have to make their own way. They are each other's escape. There's no room for that to become another source of dread.

Funny how becoming happy is what finally makes them miserable. Their whole lives, they have each other. They struggle, they crash, and then they pick each other back up. They *love each other*, but eventually there isn't anything else. They grow up. They get jobs, they get an apartment, and then those jobs grow stable and they're comfortable. They're married. They make vows, for sickness and health and *love for all eternity*.

And Catra remembers. When Adora's flash blue, when they go for a walk at night and the magic glow that once entranced Catra makes her stomach turn, she remembers. She and Adora are living in different worlds. Adora is dedicated to her, she knows, but no matter what she says – and what they *don't* say – they both know that this is only a brief period in Adora's life. It feels more impactful because she has only lived a nominal amount of time so far, but even the knowledge that this will eventually be a mere blink on the scale of her life diminishes it. It robs it of some of the meaning for her that it holds for Catra.

Catra will dedicate every moment of her life to the woman she loves, and one day Adora will mourn her and move on, maybe even forget her. One day another girl will be dancing with

Adora in the kitchen. Maybe in a thousand years, Adora will have finally learned to dance. Her next wife – or at that point, maybe merely her next mortal fling – will see a version of Adora that Catra is never going to know because it will take lifetimes for her to develop from the girl that Catra loves now.

It hurts Catra so much to think about and yet somehow the other possibility isn't better. The only other option is that Adora ends up like her mother after only one lifetime: taken by grief. In that reality, Catra is her killer. It's crueler than Adora just being mortal. The weight of Adora's possible forever hangs over them for their entire lives; Catra dies thinking she's just Adora's first love but instead becomes a weight around Adora's neck, dragging her down to hell with her.

For a childhood full of hardship, Catra doesn't worry about it. For a few turbulent years of happiness, she forces it down whenever it comes up. At thirty, Adora meets and befriends another immortal and Catra can't ignore it anymore. As Glimmer and Adora become friends, Catra watches a bond that will last forever bloom. Adora can say that Catra is more important, that she loves her with her entire heart, but it doesn't matter how she thinks she feels now: death is hunting only one of them, and it leaves Catra crying and choking on her shallow breaths at night.

Depression, they call it. They give her pills and all they do is make her sleep so she can't cry. She's a mess, dragging Adora down. Adora's gaze is always distraught as she hovers over her and wishes she could help her wife, but there's no *helping* Catra. Even on her good days, the smallest thing can send her crashing down and she has to watch the light of happiness die in Adora's gaze as Catra is reduced to a crying huddle. Adora takes to walking on eggshells, but they can't sneak around this like they used to sneak around the home.

There's no happy ending for them. Catra's love for Adora defines every inch of her soul, and maybe if she loved her a little less she would get to love her *more*, but she can't take it. Sometimes she can barely function, too consumed by her fear and depression and looming dread. She isn't happy when she's counting the minutes they get. She's miserable, and worse, she's making Adora miserable too. Every day she thinks of what can't be and what *will*, and she realizes she's killing them both before time can do it.

She breaks her own heart and she sets them both free. She leaves.

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At sixty, Adora finally looks like an adult. Immortals age only a bit behind mortals at first, but then they age on the span of centuries. At eighteen, they look maybe sixteen if they're lucky, but it quickly slows. In her last memory of Catra, she looked mature compared to Adora's babyface. Now Adora looks in the mirror and thinks she could easily be placed in her mid-twenties, maybe even her *late*. She isn't likely to visibly age much, if at all, further for several lifetimes, but she finally looks old enough to have been with Catra.

At least, Catra as she was when she lost her.

At least once a month now, she glances at the calendar and wonders: is she still out there? For years, she looked in every crowd for a familiar pair of ears. She hoped to see her again, that as the years painfully passed maybe they would at least bring perspective or maturity that could help her repair things with the only woman she ever wanted to love.

Part of her understands. She watched Catra struggle as she sank into depression. The rest of her wishes Catra would have talked to her more, before they got to the point where the mere reminder of their lifespans sent Catra so far into a panic attack that they never had a chance of planning what they truly wanted for their lives so they could spend them *together*.

Adora has lived as long without Catra now as she did with her and it hasn't stopped it from hurting. Catra was all she had, and even once she wasn't, when they both had friends and even once Adora had Glimmer and her family, Catra was still all she *wanted*. They never fell out of love. Catra still loved her just as much the day she left her as the day they first kissed. That's what makes it impossible for Adora to accept, but every day the chances grow that Catra isn't out there to find anymore.

The cruelest thing, Adora thinks, is that magicats don't tend to live as long as even mortal humans. They didn't know that back then, before the internet existed and it was easy to find terrible information like that, but Adora knows it now and thinks about it often. Almost as often as she wonders if Catra did move on in the end. Maybe Catra was right that they were living on different time scales. It didn't feel like it to Adora when all she wanted was her life with Catra, but now she has forever to waste, and so she does, not ready to move on as long as there's the slimmest chance of finding each other again.

The only thing that kept the grief from getting her, she thinks, is how much hope there was. She was heartbroken when Catra said she couldn't take it anymore, but she thought they could fix it. When it became clear they *couldn't*, she thought they could reunite. Her heart broke in one shot, but the grief? It has been a slow build. Slow certainty that Catra wasn't coming back. Slow certainty that if she did at this point, she would be a different person, changed by time. And now, the slow fear creeping in that she's already dead.

Adora tries to be happy, but she doesn't try to move on. Maybe in another forty years, when it's sure that Catra is gone, but maybe Catra's plan to save Adora from mourning will only make it a slow, uncertain build that merely takes longer because she wasn't in Catra's life to know the moment it happened. She carries on because she has friends and she doesn't want to make their lonely existence even lonelier, but she never stops wishing she was mortal and always had been.

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Cyra remembers the blonde girl slowly. She befriends every human girl who looks like her at playgrounds and daycare, but they hold nothing to the memories Cyra has of the girl she

thought was her only love, doomed from the start.

Her parents are baffled when she starts insisting her name is Catra at only three years old, but they love her. Catra doesn't remember not being loved yet, but she does soon as more comes back to her. Her moms let her go by a different name, probably thinking it's a phase until Catra finally explains the memories that bubble up in her dreams at night or in flashes when something triggers them during the day. They drive two days to take her to the Temple of the Stars in Halfmoon.

Reincarnation isn't impossible, but the odds are. Every race has a different form of immortality, each rarer than the last, and this is hers: a cycle of life and death, of new families and lost loves.

Her mothers love her so much. They take it in stride. They move to Halfmoon so Catra can have guidance over the years as she grows. Reluctantly, Catra lets the priestesses record the process. She's the first who has come to them in a long time. The old lines should still be out there somewhere, but they are so easy to lose track of when all it takes is one rebirth not returning to declare themselves. As an eight-and-forty-seven-year-old, Catra kind of gets it, but on her first second-life, she is grateful for the guidance.

Her parents support her, even if they mourn her childhood innocence that never really comes, the memories coming back as soon as she would start developing a personality beyond "baby." Still, Catra never got to be young before, and she certainly never got the security of a family that loves her, so she languishes in their love. She might not have ever gotten a real youth in any life, but she died relatively young – still younger than her moms are, at least – and they have a lot to teach her.

Catra will always be different, though. She isn't a kid, but she isn't an adult either, and she can't relate to a lot of people "her age." When she should be in middle school, suffering through basic mathematics, Catra is attending private tutoring and thinking back on her old career, rewriting her perfect future with a family to support her through school so she can really be something.

When Catra is eighteen, her moms pay for her to go away for college, off to a big human city where she can be anonymous. In Halfmoon, people who go to the temple enough recognize her, and those people whisper to their friends and children when they see Catra out in public. It's like small town gossip, except Halfmoon isn't even small, Catra has just reached local celebrity status in the most morbid way.

Bright Moon is freedom. Her parents joke that she's leaving the moon that's always locked beneath the South Pole of the planet for one of the bright ones that makes a nightly journey across the sky. Catra is looking forward to it. She's trying to embody her supposed youth. She's excited for university, and to get an advanced degree for the first time, and one day to become an expert with the strangest resume ever, backed by the word of the priestesses that *legally*, no one can deny. She's on her first second-life now, though, and doesn't have to worry about the mess of paperwork it takes to inherit something from a past life yet.

She died at thirty-nine. She never went to school, never did more than work a simple trade and break her own heart. She lived the rest of her days after Adora listless. She didn't have

the daily panic attacks anymore and her depressive episodes were *episodes* rather than constant, but she's not surprised she didn't last much longer. It is cast in a crueler light by her new life, but she is more at peace now than she was.

More, not wholly. She still thinks about finding Adora, sometimes. Often. She does a few quick searches that never make it past the first page of Google before she retreats. Adora probably wouldn't want anything to do with her after the way things ended and she has had decades to move on like Catra always feared she would. As she nears completion of her bachelors, they have been apart for almost as long as they were together. Adora certainly thinks she moved on or died. Catra probably wouldn't even be able to find her if she looked in earnest.

Part of her is just scared to look. She wishes she had never remembered the haunted whisper of *I'd die with you* Adora gave as Catra packed her bags, but it was one of the earliest memories to come back. Catra knows it didn't happen, that it wasn't some kind of magic pact and Adora is likely blissfully unaware that Catra's death date has even passed, but she fears that "knowledge" is just her clinging to hope.

It might not have been magic, but it was an offer to live and die together. Catra always told herself it was a heat-of-the-moment thing. Adora could say and even mean it then, but she would eventually, if not quickly, realize she didn't actually want to die. Even if she *did*, she was immortal. It wasn't like she could guarantee grief would take her, and Catra never wanted a suicide pact. That was part of why she *left*, so Adora would be safe from her. Adora is fine, probably moved on, and she wouldn't want Catra to come crawling back after it all.

Whatever Catra knows about Adora, she already knows that she won't be moving on from her in this life. She can manage and she can build a life for herself now that she has been reborn, but she can't build a life with someone *else*. She doesn't know when she will get there, if ever, but her family are the only thing she has room for this time around.

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Sometimes Adora looks at Bow and she just feels sad.

He's demi-mortal, one of the worst ends of the stick in Adora's opinion. A long, long life, and then it's over. The pain of immortality with none of the freedom.

Then again, all those years are good for something. He and Glimmer know they'll get hundreds of years. Immortals don't tend to last forever anyway. The grief always gets them eventually. Three hundred good years together? That's something to be jealous of compared to the thirty Adora and Catra got together.

As much as she hoped to find her again, Adora had to move. There were too many hybrids where they used to live together and she suspected Catra left town after their divorce anyway. Magicats are pretty rare in most parts of the planet. Living almost anywhere else would give

her less heart palpitations. Her heart does the same leap it always does when she spots one in a crowd, but it's rarer now, and that's… better.

It feels like forgetting Catra until she does spot a magicat again and it hurts all over again. The move at least brought her to Bright Moon and let Glimmer and Bow meet when she came with Adora. He's freshly off his masters and they're still moving slow given the gap between them, but Adora stands beside them as a cautionary tale: don't hold back when tomorrow it could all be gone. If they get three hundred years, will they regret wasting the first forty? For Adora, she knows her answer would be yes.

They're friends now, but taking just a few years to move into anything more probably won't hurt in the long run, Adora is just still guided by heartbreak. One day, they're out shopping together and Adora sees a pair of ears down the street. She turns like she always does, looking back at the magicat standing beside the park bench, nose down in her phone as she texts.

Adora's heart breaks in an all-new way. It isn't Catra, a good forty years too young, but she looks so much like her it strangles Adora's throat just like the knowledge of Adora's immortality used to grip Catra's. She has short hair and is turned slightly so Adora can only see one yellow eye – certainly joined by an identical twin on the other side – but she reminds Adora of the Catra that she first got to love, back when things were *perfect*. They were struggling to make rent, but they were free of the orphanage and so in love that they were blind to the eternity pressing down on them.

This, it turns out, is even worse than seeing a magicat with gray-streaked fur and wondering if that's what Catra looks like now.

Then the magicat looks up, checking the crosswalk light, and it gets even worse. She does have both her eyes. She might as well be her daughter.

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For all that Catra's parents know she has forty years of experience behind her current twenty, they still worry about her up in the city, sometimes. She gives it until she enrolls in grad school for them to move to be closer to her. She's pretty sure, at this point, that they're just waiting to know for sure where grad school *is* before they sell their house.

They're not rich, though, so if Catra wants to go to grad school, she can't afford a car in the city. She's fine with that. Inflation has made it harder to be twenty years old now than it was in her last life, but she's used to spending her days on foot. She regularly walks from her apartment, to school, to work, back to school for another class, and then back home. It's on her final trip home after a long week that she decides to take a detour because she has *earned* a treat and a new satellite of a bakery they had back in Halfmoon just opened. It's a part of town she usually can't afford to spend money in, but this once won't hurt.

She's waiting to cross the street, texting her moms to arrange their visit during the upcoming school break, when she looks up and sees her.

Catra's heart stops. It's midday, but one of the moons is still out. It's hard to tell if the shimmer in her hair is from the moon or just the sunlight catching her blond hair. Her eyes are unmistakable, and her face…

Catra can die a thousand times, but she'll never forget that face. It feels like a cruel joke that when she sees it again, it looks heartbroken just like she remembers it. For a long moment, she stares at Adora and Adora stares at her. The breeze blows, ruffling Adora's hair in the wind and making Catra aware of the sparkly pink nightmare she has always partially blamed for triggering her breakdown standing beside Adora, but still neither of them move.

Then, finally, Adora turns away. Catra lets out a shaky breath, her throat tight as Adora strides away. It's the cruel proof to Catra's worst fears. Adora doesn't want her. Catra remembers what dying feels like, choking until there was nothing left, and she swears this was it. It creeps over her, her fingers starting to tingle and vision blurring. She blinks to clear it and realizes Adora has her shoulders hunched, leaned against a building and crying as her friends hover around her, trying to comfort her and ask what's wrong.

It hits Catra's lungs like a cold shock of air, forcing her to breathe again as she watches Adora shake her head. Catra is too far to hear, but she can *tell* Adora is assuring her friends she's fine.

She still knows her.

She barely checks the street before starting forward on unsteady feet, just enough presence of mind to know this is the *worst* time to get hit by a car and die again. The light is still red, but there's an opening and she doesn't care. She dashes forward, stumbling on usually graceful feet, but the blur is still clearing from her vision when she gets close enough to hear what Adora and her two friends are saying.

"I'm sorry," Adora says through tears, apologizing for something that could not be further from her fault.

"Adora, it's okay, just tell us what's going on. We want to help," Glimmer says. Catra feels ice pour down her spine when she realizes they're holding hands.

"You can't. She just- She looks like-" Adora's breaths are coming too fast for her to finish that sentence. It looks a lot like Catra's old episodes. Glimmer glances up, her brow furrowed, and then freezes when she sees Catra.

Feet stretch between them as for a long moment, they only stare at each other. Then Adora hauls in a loud, shaking breath and Catra breaks eye contact, propelling herself forward.

"Hey, Adora." Catra's shaking voice is almost too quiet to be heard over Adora trying to control her tears, but she can't force it louder as she tries to get Adora's attention. Adora freezes, her breaths switching to short, shallow ones, like she's trying to quiet herself to hear. Catra steps forward, reaching out and pushing Glimmer's shoulder without a fucking care so

she can step around Adora and get close enough to see her face. “Adora,” she reiterates, ignoring the beginning of Glimmer’s curse. Adora’s eyes, trained down on her shoes as she hunches over, are wide.

Slowly, she looks up. Glimmer has a hand fisted in the shoulder of Catra’s shirt and is saying *something*, probably for her to back up, but Catra can barely hear it.

She thought when they locked eyes across the street that Adora looked as heartbroken as she left her, but she was wrong. Time blurred her memory. *This* is what Adora looked like when Catra left – what Catra looked like too.

Catra drops to her knees, slowed by Glimmer’s hand on her shirt, but all it really does is lessen the impact of her knees colliding with the pavement as she throws her arms around Adora’s shoulders and pulls her into a hug.

“You can’t be,” Glimmer says above her. It’s not a full sentence, but it cuts through the water in Catra’s ears because it’s the first thing she has said that sounds awestruck – even if it’s in a bad way – rather than angry. Adora’s fingers curl into Catra’s shirt as she struggles for breath.

“You’re- You’re too young,” Adora manages to get out, sounding like she’s reasoning with herself. Catra tightens her arms around Adora, dragging one hand up from her back to bury it in her hair. Adora loved having her hair touched, at least as long as Catra wasn’t messing with her stupid ponytail, but it’s missing today. Maybe it has been for decades. Fashions have certainly changed.

“I’m sixty, actually,” Catra murmurs back to her, speaking around a lump in her own throat. Adora jerks back, her hands still clutching to Catra, but she pulls far enough back to stare into her eyes. She looks shocked. Disbelieving eyes dart over Catra’s face. Catra reluctantly pulls a hand off of Adora to reach for the high collar of her shirt, pulling it down to reveal the scar in the center of her throat.

“Asphyxia. Or choking, maybe, at thirty-nine. I think the priestesses tracked down the death report, but I was ‘a kid’ and too young to read how I died,” Catra says, voice shaking. Adora’s vision stays stuck on her throat, on the first of many scars that will bloom with each new death and life, the only ones that will carry over with her.

“Wh- what?” Adora stammers, but there’s an edge to her voice now, the beginning of dawning hope. Catra swallows. She isn’t sure if it’s the scar or the lump in her throat that bobs.

“Magicats can’t live forever, but we can live again,” she says. She’s sure Adora knows it – she had vaguely heard about it back in her first life, even if information wasn’t available as readily then as it is now – but Adora is in more shock than even Catra is right now.

Adora’s jaw turns slack. Slowly, her fingers loosen from Catra shirt. Catra drops her collar to quickly reach for Adora’s shoulder and latch on with both hands, not ready for her to recoil, but after several long moments of staring at her, tears fall from Adora’s eyes again and she pitches forward, wrapping her arms around Catra and hauling her close. It scrapes Catra’s

knees against the pavement, painful even through her jeans, but she just wraps around Adora and clutches her back.

People are probably staring at them, and the boy with them is murmuring *is she…?* to Glimmer and being answered with a disbelieving *no fucking way*, but all of that comes second. Everything has always come second to Adora.

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Adora is still in a daze when they reach the car. They only get there by virtue of Glimmer and Bow shepherding them. Glimmer is clearly distrusting, but Bow keeps cutting her off when she tries to start the inquisition and she drives them back in relative silence.

Adora stares at Catra the whole time, their fingers interlaced as they sit in the backseat together. Catra's gaze often darts around the car or out the windows, but it returns to Adora frequently.

"You're…" Adora trails off, struggling for a moment to remember dates and years when her mind and heart feel like they're filled with static, "twenty?" she finally finishes. The moment she speaks, Catra's eyes are locked on her. She gives her a smile warbling between teasing and nonexistent.

"Twenty-one. Don't tell me you forgot my birthday," she says, her thumb brushing against Adora's knuckles. Adora vehemently shakes her head.

"No, I- Whenever I see someone who could be- I thought I was losing my mind. I might still be losing my mind," Adora manages. Catra looks away, towards the front of the car.

"Your input, Sparkles? You met me before," Catra says. Her voice is so familiar. Adora wants to close her eyes and float in it, for Catra to talk about anything, forever, a bedtime story to drift Adora off to sleep until she wakes again and can confirm whether or not this is a dream.

"I hate your fucking guts. You broke Adora's heart. But no one is as annoying as you. I'm checking out your story, but I don't know how else to explain this," Glimmer says from the front seat.

"Glimmer…" Bow admonishes softly as Catra's ears pin back and she turns to look out the window instead. Adora watches her throat bob as she swallows, the high collar of her shirt obscuring the scar that connects it all.

"I was really fucked up, Adora. I'm pretty sure I died from a fucking panic attack. My vision was going black and I tried to drink water to down my tranquilizers, but I couldn't control my breath long enough to do even that. I remember as much of it as you can," Catra murmurs, gaze still fixed out the window. Adora struggles for her next breath. She squeezes Catra's hand and gets a small relief when Catra squeezes back.

“It was better after we… I broke both our damn hearts, but the depression got a bit better until it didn’t and I ended up here. As fucked up as it is, I was right to be afraid, leaving just didn’t save me. Now I have- I have a family and shit. I have a future and support. Dying was the best thing that ever happened to me,” Catra says. Adora feels like she’s stuck inside her own body, screaming while she watches herself sit there, unmoving. “The best thing aside from you, anyway,” Catra adds, her voice so quiet Adora barely hears it and so strained she barely makes it out.

“Catra,” Adora manages to whisper. Catra turns her head back, having to fight to make her eyes look at Adora rather than through her.

“You were the first thing I remembered. Before my own name, I remembered you,” Catra says.

It hits Adora almost as hard as the first whisper of her name did.

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The sky is tinged pink and orange, the sun setting and Adora’s hair gaining that subtle luminosity as more of the moons begin to peek out overheard. A subtle breeze gives her hair life just like it ruffles Catra’s fur.

“So, what happens now?” Catra asks, face tilted up to the sky. Adora has chairs on her balcony, but they’re both sprawled out on the tiles, Catra with her back against the door to inside and Adora opposite her, leaning against the railing. Catra is pretty sure Glimmer and Bow are inside using Adora’s laptop to furiously research her story. They’ll see how that goes. There’s likely nothing easily searchable that identifies her, just articles with the identity redacted. They’ll have to call the temple and that will take a while.

At some point Glimmer opened a bottle of wine – *not* in a celebratory way – and Catra said sure to a glass because it means fuck-all to her magicat genes. She sips it as she waits for Adora to reply. Adora is still trying to rehydrate from the earlier crying. She has a bottle of water all but forgotten beside her.

“I think… that’s up to you,” Adora finally murmurs. Catra snorts, dropping her chin to send Adora an incredulous look. Adora just looks back, not joining in on the joke. The ghost of a smile slowly drops from Catra’s face.

“Adora, I left you.” Adora winces, but Catra keeps pushing on. “I wasn’t in the shape to be with anyone, hell, to even be *around* anyone with how I ruined everything I touched, but I did that to us. I threw away everything we could have had because I was so scared of what would happen next. It’s easy for me to say what I want now, when I have my life together and I’ve had therapy, but you had to live with the choice I made. I don’t think I get to make this one,” Catra says.

For a long moment, Adora stares at her. Catra can see the haunted look in her eye, the proof that Adora still remembers that day vividly. Catra takes a drink for an excuse to look away. They haven't talked too much about where Adora is in her life now. It's pretty obvious she isn't with someone because they would have been mentioned by now – if there was anyone, Glimmer probably would have called her up by now and told her to come back and get her girl before she makes a big, dumb mistake – but Catra's breakdown was fueled by how deeply she loved Adora and how scared she was of being nothing to her. She would worry even if she hadn't done so much to drive Adora away.

"I don't think you made a choice," Adora finally says, her voice low. Catra's gaze snaps to her. Adora's gaze slowly wanders up to meet her from where it was staring indistinctly into the living room behind her. Adora licks her lips. "Loving me was killing you. That's not making much of a choice," Adora says, her voice still low and haunted. Catra tries to swallow, doesn't make it all the way down, and then has to force her throat to work its muscles again to finally finish.

"Knowing that there was ever going to be a time when I wasn't there to love you or you didn't love me back was killing me. It's not like leaving bought me much time. It only stretched out my misery for a few more years, really. Depression still got me in the end, and that was all me," Catra replies in a whisper, her face tilting down in shame. Adora shifts, sitting up a little from her slouch, though she doesn't move any closer.

"I think it bought us forever, actually," Adora corrects, voice still low, but a little less dark. Catra's brows draw together and she looks up. Adora looks anxious, glancing down and reaching for her water. As she unscrews the lid, she speaks. "If- If you had died from depression at thirty-two or something, I think that would have been it for me too, knowing I was the reason. If you had stayed and died… I would have gone, too, and you would have been reborn alone. I wouldn't be looking at you right now," Adora elaborates. Catra chokes on a sob.

"That's not- That's not how depression works. It wasn't your *fault* that I was the way I was," Catra manages, looking up and holding desperate eye contact with Adora. For a moment, Adora just takes steady breaths and then sips a slow drink of her water.

"Wouldn't have mattered if you were gone. It didn't matter that we loved each other then, did it? It still scared you. The *mind* doesn't work like that. Blame is emotional, not logical," Adora says, slowly. It clearly takes work to keep from crying again.

Catra takes a deep breath and pitches her head back, staring up at the stars and counting her breaths. Blame is nasty and their minds are vicious, but they're here, aren't they? Against all odds, they're sitting together thirty years later, and nothing is perfect, but those deadlines and time scales that paralyzed Catra when she was thirty aren't a barrier back at twenty.

"I want to get my degree. I want to get into the masters program at BMU," Catra starts to list off, finally answering Adora's earlier silent question. In the corner of her eye, she sees Adora lower her water bottle. Catra swallows, steeling herself. "I want you to meet my moms when they visit next month. They've heard a *lot* about you. They'll be excited." Catra's next breath is shaking. "I'm still going to love you no matter what. As long as you're even half of who

you once were, I'm always going to love you. You wrote that into my DNA when we were kids," she whispers.

She doesn't look away from the moons overhead, trying to focus her vision until she can see the faint glimmer of stars in the pink canopy as Adora sits silent across from her.

Adora shifts. Catra tries not to look, but then Adora is crawling over her legs and Catra is blinking up at her face, Adora's hands on either side of hers. Her eyes are searching and a little desperate, scanning over Catra's face and then sinking in her gaze, looking for answers. Catra breathes shallowly as she stares up into those blue, blue eyes.

Slowly, the desperation fades from them. Slowly, their breaths turn even. In an instant, Adora leans forward and kisses her. In the same instant, Catra is kissing her back.

It has been thirty years. It's a new body, for as much as it's her old one. Catra feels clumsy as she reaches for Adora and ends up with one arm thrown over her back, clutching her, and the other latched onto her elbow because it's the first thing she could reach.

Catra knows that she is just a healthier version of her old self. She hopes the same is true for Adora, but even if she's kissing a ghost and a memory, it doesn't matter. Catra has had her pity party. She has forever now, and she'll ride this out with Adora until she's certain the girl she loved is gone.

She doesn't think she's gone at all. This kiss feels familiar in its clumsiness, like the one at seventeen when they finally figured out what this was and that it meant they could get *involved* with this one. Not that the kiss is inappropriate or anything, but after this long, it could never be anything but deep.

Catra's ears swivel around as there is a shout from inside, followed by pounding footsteps.

"Hey! Stop that! This is *not* healthy!" Glimmer demands as she comes lumbering up to the door, having spotted the transgression. Adora shifts, throwing her arm up to brace against the door and leverage as much weight as she can against it to keep it closed. The movement necessitates their faces shifting enough for their lips to part, but that just leaves them so close that Catra can't focus her vision, their breaths puffing against each other.

Adora swallows audibly, holding Catra's blurry gaze.

"That was… She's probably right. I just had to," Adora admits as Glimmer pounds on the door and demands Adora open it. Catra huffs a shaking laugh, reaching up with the hand that *was* on Adora's elbow and burying it in her hair.

"Yeah. I'm glad you did, though," Catra returns. Adora leans back enough for Catra to see her smile. There's an uncertain edge to it that Catra is sure is mirrored in her own when she smiles back, but there's *hope,* too. For a half a second, Adora's gaze flicks down and she wavers closer, but then Glimmer pushes on the door again and she reluctantly leans back.

It's only a few inches, but it's firmly out of kissing range, where she probably should be, as loathe as Catra is to admit Glimmer is right. She swallows, sitting up herself so that if

Glimmer succeeds in opening the door it won't totally knock her aside. Adora is still trying to hold it shut, her gaze locked on Catra's.

"All I ever wanted was to love you. I'd like the chance to do it again now," Adora whispers. Catra sucks in a shaking breath, the words pouring into her like ice water, a shock she wasn't expecting.

Through the glass, Glimmer admonishes, "Adora, *no*."

Slowly, Adora smiles. A *real* smile, maybe slightly manic from the emotions of the day. Catra giggles, and then it builds to a laugh, and suddenly they're both laughing and Adora is tackling her. Her wine glass gets knocked aside, pouring red across the balcony tiles, but Adora uses her momentum to roll them away from it and Catra is too caught up in the glory of being in Adora's arms again to care about her pants potentially getting stained or Glimmer finally opening the door now that they aren't blocking it.

"You're *both* going to therapy," Glimmer declares, breathless from the effort of fighting the door. Adora laughs loudly as Catra fights through her own to speak.

"Already went, Sparkles. It might help you with your anger issues, though," she returns before dissolving into giggles as Adora joins her, nuzzling her and immediately earning nuzzling back.

It isn't fixed, but it's a moment of fresh air after a long, long rain.

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Catra is supposed to be leaving, probably. It's late, she probably doesn't live close since Adora has never seen her before, and as much as she is afraid to look away and have Catra's hallucination disappear, it would probably be best for them both if they took some time to process by themselves. Glimmer and Bow are just kind of *hovering* around the living room, clearly not going to leave until Catra does – probably after, waiting to check in on Adora as much as they are making sure they don't do something regrettable if left alone.

Catra is standing near to counter, largely frozen as they just stare at each other, trying to find something to say. Finally, her phone chimes and breaks the awkward hovering loop they're all caught in. Catra pulls her phone out, checking the screen and sighing.

"That's my mom. I should get back. I've got homework to do and… to figure out how to explain this," Catra admits reluctantly, looking down and tucking her phone away. Instantly, Adora's heart pulses in her chest, a flash of fear telling her Catra is leaving and that's it.

It's not it. They've talked about this. They've exchanged numbers and they're going to… figure something out. This is the first day she's seeing her for the rest of forever. Step one of a thousand.

Adora's *steps* carry her forward without thinking, backing Catra against the counter as soon as she straightens so she can pin her there and wrap her in a hug. She catches her off guard, but Catra only tenses for a second before going boneless.

"Uh, Adora, we're… happy for you, but I think it would be good for you to exercise some healthy limits until you've had some time to process," Bow says, stepping closer while Glimmer crosses twice as far, both of them apparently ready to *intervene* before Adora has regrets. Catra growls quietly, wrapping her arms back around Adora, clutching her close so the vibration rattles between their chests. Adora is still a little wrung out and the mild tickling of the rumble gets her giggling.

"Fussy kitty," she murmurs to Catra, tucking her face in and nuzzling at her throat. It's so familiar, a body she once knew well. This interaction happened a hundred times when they were kids. The growl transforms, warping its dimensions until it's an amused purr that has Adora's heart palpitating.

"You're an idiot," Catra responds, voice just as soft and low. Their audience is likely exchanging looks as they try to decide what to do, but Adora doesn't care about that, she cares about the return of an embrace she thought gone forever.

"I can't help it. You're here," Adora pauses to nuzzle Catra's throat again, as if she has any hope of marking it. "You're here and you didn't move on or get remarried and you don't hate me," Adora lists off. It's a morbid list of things to say with a blissful tone, maybe, but even if Catra's life took turns from Adora's worst nightmares, they somehow made their way back to here.

"I could never hate you. It has been thirty damn years and I still love you," Catra finally responds, just barely above a whisper. Adora swallows hard around a lump in her throat. She lifts her head, rubbing their cheeks together. It's just meant to be affectionate, but then a chuckle manages to bubble up in Catra and Adora sets to scent marking herself, chasing that laugh. One of Catra's hands comes up to steady – or maybe *still* her – but Adora has determination and a desperate need to show affection. No one has understood this side of her since she lost Catra because Catra was the one who *made* it.

"I want to smell like you," Adora says, tone a little whining and a little teasing when Catra tries to hold her head still, effectively stopping her. She might not be able to smell it herself, but she'll *know* and that's enough. For a moment, a purr rolls between them.

"No," Catra says, the purr dying with her words. Adora's breath catches, her eyes widening as she stills.

"N-no?" she manages, trying to force down her heartrate as she stares over Catra's shoulder into the kitchen. Catra's hand that was – essentially – pushing her face away hooks around the back of her head to pull her closer into her shoulder.

"If I mark you, you won't take a damn shower, and you need one. You smell like salt and we rolled around on the floor. *Outside*," Catra corrects. Adora blows out a shaky breath as her body tries to return to normal operations. She squeezes Catra tighter for a moment, getting one last bit of tight hugging in and feeling something in her chest unknot when Catra clings

back, before she reluctantly loosens her arms around Catra and pulls back so they can look at each other again.

Catra's eyes are open, pupils partially dilated as she looks at Adora with what is probably the exact same expression that Adora is wearing. Adora swallows, reaching up and framing Catra's face in her hands.

"I'll see you tomorrow?" she asks, her voice fragile. Catra's breathing stutters, but she nods. Adora steadies herself by smoothing Catra's ruffled cheek tufts down. "And the day after?" she asks, just as much hope in her voice. Catra breathes out the ghost of a laugh, a fleeting smile curving onto her lips. She reaches up, grabbing Adora's wrists and anchoring them both with the weight of her arms.

"And the day after, if you want it. I live here. I'm not going anywhere, at least not until grad school, and hopefully not even then," Catra promises. Adora closes her eyes, nodding as she tries to internalize that.

Catra is here. She doesn't want to leave anymore.

The next breath comes out like a punch to her lungs.

Catra wants to be *here*.

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Being in the room with Adora again, Catra almost wants to say she would have gone looking for her eventually if fate didn't bring them together. She wants to say it, but the weight of her insecurities will always be there, and the voice that said she already ruined them had successfully beat her back every time before when her hands wanted to reach out into the darkness.

Talking to Adora again, seeing her, just being *around* her, that seems so dumb.

In some ways, the first day is easy. It's hard and terrifying, but she doesn't have to sit there and hear Adora rattle off how it broke her to be alone, how she has spent years wondering if Catra got remarried and moved on or was already dead somewhere and she would never, ever know, there would just eventually be a time when she knew it was impossible that Catra had survived that long. The things she put Adora through are almost a funhouse mirror version of the things her own mind tormented her with until it eventually broke them apart.

It isn't much easier to talk about her side of it, to talk with hindsight about what was actually happening in her brain that forced them apart or the few years where she barely managed to keep her head above the surface before she was finally forced under again. They have to talk about it, though. If they want to ever look at each other and not be haunted, they have to.

They can't do it all at once, though. They portion it out, in days or weeks, and will probably take years getting through it all.

They have that time now, though.

For the moment, she lets Adora just ruffle her hair and ask why she cut it. She lets Adora pull her into her arms for no reason, and she marks Adora any time they meet at one of their apartments. She does her best not to fight with Glimmer, who she never liked and who hates her now but keeps insisting on being around. Glimmer clearly doesn't trust her to not hurt Adora again, but Catra isn't in the dark place she was then and the last thing she wants to do is hurt Adora now.

As much as none of it was good or fair, she decides to follow Adora's mindset and just be happy they're here now.

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Catra as a student is still taking some getting used to. Catra with a bounce in her step and a youthful air to her is something Adora hadn't seen in years even before they broke up. Sometimes Adora almost feels like she's talking to Catra's daughter, a perfect copy without the trauma, too young and too happy to be the woman who left Adora.

She isn't the woman who left Adora, though. She's the teenager she fell in love with, she's the little girl she snuck through the halls of the orphanage with, she's the woman who cried with happiness when they got married, and she's someone brand new, too. Someone with a lot more chances to be happy. The new Catra is far from carefree, but even as she discusses her own death, she isn't wracked with depression and fear like Adora's Catra was thirty years ago.

If happy-Catra is hard to get used to, Catra with *parents* is a whole other beast. Adora had at least known a happy Catra before. The version of Catra freshest in her mind – the version she was apparently rightfully afraid would consume her – was deeply depressed, but they had been happy once. They never had a family. They grew up in the kind of orphanage they make horror documentaries about now or visit on ghost-hunting shows looking for tormented souls. Adora had vague memories of her parents and that was it. Catra was given up at birth. There was no one left to want them.

Felina greets Adora with a bright smile and the warmth of a mom. Leona takes Adora's hand as if to shake it and instead pulls her right off balance and into a tight hug. Leona and Catra both laugh at how it catches Adora by surprise. After a quick squeeze, Leona lets her go, holding her at arm's length so she can get a look at her.

Neither of Catra's moms look like her – Leona is about her height but with a light gray coat and fluffy tail while Felina towers over them all with a blazing orange coat with a few white hairs streaked throughout, both of them sporting amber eyes – but maybe there's a

resemblance with her sperm donor or it's just not needed for Catra to come back as she was. These women still raised her. Adora would say *again*, but no one really raised them the first time. All they knew was punishment. Now Leona insists on hugging Catra after Adora "because hugs are going around" even though the couple has been at Catra's apartment since last night and undoubtedly already hugged her – probably multiple times from what Adora is seeing now.

"Mom, you're embarrassing," Catra complains even as she lets Leona squish her in an enthusiastic hug. Adora's heart beats a strange rhythm hearing the words. Catra really has adopted the couple.

"Embarrassing? I haven't begun embarrassing you," she says, letting go of Catra and turning towards Adora with a grin. Catra's eyes widen. "It's really so good to meet you. When Catra was a baby-"

"No! No, no, no," Catra scrambles to stop her, grabbing her shoulder as if to physically pull her away from Adora. Leona cackles as Catra stands in front of her and turns to pout at her, showing Adora her back and lashing tail.

"Adora met baby-me before, we do *not* need to rehash any of this shit," Catra says. Every tail in the room is swishing, Catra embarrassed and her moms amused. In the corner of her eye, Adora catches Felina making eye contact. When Adora turns her head towards her, Felina's lips twitch a barely-contained smile.

"What your mother was trying to say is that your favorite thing to babble this time around was '*ora, 'ora*,'" Felina says. Adora's breath leaves her all at once. Catra stills. Slowly, she turns her head to look at Felina. Her cheeks are pink.

"It was?" Catra asks in a small voice. Well, at least Adora isn't the only one hearing life-altering information for the first time. Felina can't hide her smile now as she nods. Leona is openly grinning, petting Catra's shoulder as she processes that.

"We always thought 'go' was your first word, but it turns out you had been talking for a lot longer than we knew," Leona says, her voice warm, affectionate even as her gaze drifts to Adora. Adora is pretty sure she is feeling a brand-new emotion, which she really didn't think would happen at sixty. She thinks she smiles back. She tries, anyway.

Slowly, Catra straightens up and wraps an arm around herself, peeking at Adora. Whatever she sees, it makes her blush harder and quickly look away.

"I told you that you were the first thing I remembered," she mutters, like it's hard to admit it again. Maybe because her moms are looking at her with shining pride in their eyes. Adora has had that look trained at her – in a parental way – maybe once from Angella and it was a lot. It's a lot just to see it aimed at *Catra*, but in a good way. As much as has happened, Adora is so happy Catra has had a family like this in their time apart. She was always the only person who loved Catra like that. She can see how much her family loves her in their interactions. It's what Catra deserved to have, probably *needed* to have in order to get anywhere near half-healed.

Adora holds her hand out and Catra unfurls from her embarrassed curl, her eyes fixed on the offered hand and ears twitching.

Catra crosses the gap and takes Adora's hand, settling by her side. They still fit together so well, magnetizing towards each other when they're in the same room together. Catra's parents may be new, but this pull has defined them since they were kids. They can figure out how to navigate everything else even in this new world of *childhood stories*.

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Catra's moms love Adora. Of course they do. Catra has told them a lot about her, and though she would never say it where *Adora* can hear, she thinks even her stories don't do her justice.

When she first told her moms that she found Adora again, of course they said, "That's great, sweetie!" but there was that anxious *hovering* in Leona's voice that told Catra she was worried how it would go. That worry partially eased as Catra explained their situation and that they were going to feel out a friendship again, but meeting Adora helps a lot. Her moms stay in Bright Moon for five days and they see Adora on two of those, mostly because Catra usually sees Adora at least twice a week.

It has only been a month; they're still at the "I can't believe you're here phase," especially Adora, who sometimes struggles with the dissonance of Catra being so much younger than she has been picturing her. There's a lot of hurt between them that they need to work out. They're trying to do this *healthily*, to be friends and reintroduce themselves to each other, but that takes holding back. It only gets harder the more they relearn each other and find a familiar soul meeting them.

Catra's natural reaction to Adora's presence is to want to be closer – to hold her hand, and kiss her, and mark her with her scent. One of those is so far off the table it's kind of laughable for her to even think it, but it's the right thing for them to hold back right now. They tend to be in contact when they're in the same room, at least, and it helps the ache in her chest some. It's not the cuddling Catra's body naturally craves, pressed together so tight they can feel each other's heartbeats, but she gets to mark Adora at least. Maybe not as freely and affectionately as she would like, but it's almost ritual at this point, just a part of their greeting. Catra arrives at Adora's loft, they hug, Catra marks her neck and the side of her head, and then they go about their day.

They started their hangout on the balcony today, Catra complaining about school and Adora listening with a smile on her face and the window billowing her hair, but eventually the wind gets too strong. When Catra pins her ears back against it, Adora suggests they head back inside. Catra agrees, following behind her, but she reconsiders her choice when Adora sees her out of the wind for the first time and laughs at her.

"Your hair is *everywhere*. You look like cartoon dynamite exploded in your face," Adora tells her, still laughing to herself as she gestures vaguely toward the couch. Catra huffs and crosses

her arms, but she walks over and drops down in a huff. Adora's eyes are still dancing when she follows and sits beside her, reaching out. Catra feels her cheeks heat as Adora threads her fingers through her hair, trying to smooth it back into something approaching order. "See, when it was long it had too much weight for this to happen," Adora says, still seeming endlessly amused by what *really* can't be that bad.

"Yeah, I know, it gave me a fucking neckache every time it was wet," Catra complains. That's not why she cut it – when her memories from later in life started filtering in, she wanted something to differentiate herself from that broken version of her – but it is one of the reasons she doesn't intend to grow it out again soon.

"It *is* better for scritchies," Adora concedes, her fingers catching behind Catra's ears and scratching. A purr immediately rattles to life in Catra's chest. She feels a little breathless, staring into Adora's sparkling eyes as her fingers work magic against her scalp. This is one of the things she missed and told herself it was stupid to. Her moms would pet her, but it is so different, *means* something different – from a parent, from another magicat – than Adora's fingers that have always known exactly where to catch.

Slowly, the look on Adora's face shifts, morphing from laughter to something softer. Her gaze holds Catra's, maybe watching the same transformation take over her as bad thoughts form, not for the first time. This *is* the first time Adora's hands have been threaded through her hair as the urge took her, though. It's the first time they've both clearly had it at the same time, Adora's tongue peeking out to lick her lips and her eyes flicking down dangerously for a moment.

They're supposed to be friends. *Ex-wives* is a whole minefield to navigate even when they still love each other. They said that first day that they want to love each other again, but there are so many forms that could take and no matter what Catra *wants*, they need to take longer to work things out before they get there. She knows this.

She still kisses Adora anyway. Adora might kiss her, actually, but Catra surges forward and climbs into her lap, so enough blame is on her. She doesn't care. Adora's hands clutch her close as their chests press together and it's everything Catra has been wanting for weeks.

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They so shouldn't be doing this. Adora knows that as soon as Catra's weight settles in her lap and her hands want to migrate down, running over her. She fists them in Catra's hair instead, hanging on as Catra deepens the kiss. Catra's tongue licks into her mouth, but Adora is the one who parts her lips for her first. They kissed that first day and it was amazing, but this kiss is everything that one wasn't – filthy, deep, and desperate, thirty years of build-up fueling it.

Catra purrs, arching her back to press their chests together, which lets Adora feel her purr as much as it presses their tits together. It forces a small sound out of her, too quiet to be a moan. It's a breath more than anything, but it makes a playful growl run through Catra's chest

and down Adora's throat. It has been so *long* since she felt that shiver through her. She wants it again. She wants to run her hands over Catra. She wants to pick her up and switch their positions, pressing down on her and certain she's real.

She wants to earn small sounds like the needy moan Catra cuts off before it can become more than a tiny noise in the back of her throat.

"Adora," It's so quiet, a breath she exhales before diving in for another kiss. Adora groans, feeling Catra's tail lash as Catra's hands travel down her torso, feeling her up.

This was a bad idea for the moment their lips met, but no matter what Adora wants, this is going too far now. Reluctantly, she loosens her grip on Catra's hair, gently petting over it to soothe her before loosely threading her fingers through it again. That only makes Catra purr louder.

"We shouldn't be doing this," Adora says when they part for air. Catra whines petulantly, her fingers curling into Adora's shirt as she presses in closer rather than pulling back.

"We've been so *good*, though," she complains, nudging her nose against Adora's cheek. Adora breathes out a laugh, leaning back enough to make eye contact with Catra to let her know how ridiculous she is being. She's so cute, eyes blown out and cheeks flushed, hair ruffled all over again as Adora's hands drop from it to her shoulders. Adora catches her eyes trailing down Catra's jaw, towards her neck that is absolutely off limits. Adora clears her throat, darting her gaze back up. Catra's eyes are burning. She's so caught.

"What, you want a cheat day?" Adora asks, a smile twitching at her lips. Overall, she thinks they have been doing well at actually talking about things and not rushing in too fast – maturity comes with another thirty years, apparently – but that doesn't mean they're ready for a relationship again, no matter how much Adora wants it.

Catra's eyes flash, her gaze dropping to Adora's lips.

"*Yes*." Adora's fingers tighten on Catra's shoulders, and she swears she meant to push her away, but then Catra is leaning in and Adora is pulling her close, kissing her with hunger. Catra's body arches against her and then she's shifting, repositioning in her lap so she's straddling Adora, sitting to the side. Her hands guide Adora's face to turn as she moves so the kiss never breaks. She settles with her hips pressed close to Adora's, torso draped against her.

Adora tilts her head back and lets Catra kiss her now that she's better positioned to bear down on her and take what she wants. Catra's argument really isn't compelling – they can't just *decide* this won't mess things up, either it will or it won't – but Adora's mind isn't putting up a good counterargument right now, not when Catra's thumb is pressing under her jaw and forcing her head further back. As much as Adora wants Catra, she hasn't *been* wanted either in years and it feels incredible to experience again.

Catra squirms in her lap, and at first Adora thinks she's just trying to press closer, and then she recognizes the subtle cant to her hips. She's trying to get friction against Adora's thigh. It's a maneuver Adora is familiar with, one Catra used to try to sneak past her all the time when she was worked up but didn't want to admit it yet. Every time she seemed to think it

would go unnoticed if she made the movements small enough. Apparently that hasn't changed.

"Catra," Adora says between kisses, an amused warning. If kissing is a bad idea, sex certainly is. Catra groans, frustrated, breaking the kiss and pressing their foreheads together. Both of them are breathing heavily. When Adora slits her eyes opened, they're too close to see much, but she can see Catra has her eyes screwed up.

"I want you," Catra says, her voice low and rough, but there's an edge of frustration to her voice that tells Adora that Catra knows they need to stop too. Adora's hands flex on Catra's shoulders, but she manages not to pull her close again. Adora can't wait to get her in bed, but she *will*. She'll wait until they're ready for that, because as she's feeling Catra against her again, thoughts are occurring to her.

"I want to, but we can't do this. It's definitely too soon when we still haven't caught up on certain things," Adora returns. She wants *so bad*, but she'll be the responsible one. Catra pulls back, opening her eyes to send Adora a confused look.

"Certain things?" she asks, an unsure edge to her voice. Adora blows out a breath, finally dropping her hands from Catra so she can run them over her own hair, smoothing it back.

"You're going to laugh at me," Adora mutters. Catra relaxes, a smile quirking at her lips and one ear lifting to swivel right at her, waiting to hear it. It's so cute. Fine.

"Have you… been with anybody else?" she settles on asking. They've never directly asked each other. Catra hasn't mentioned anyone, but with thirty years to cover and the delicate situation they're in, it could just have been something she hasn't wanted to say yet. Catra's ear drops back down as she stares at Adora.

"Are you serious?" she asks, ducking her head a little to bring them onto the same eye level so she can scrutinize Adora. Adora huffs a laugh, a little embarrassed, but a little relieved, too.

"I didn't think so, but when we're still in the phase where we don't *know* things like that yet, then we shouldn't be doing this," Adora explains, gesturing vaguely between then. Catra sends her an unimpressed look.

"Who would I have been with, Adora? What, you think I was cruising when I was having a panic attack weekly?" Catra asked, apparently not ready to let it go. Adora feels her cheeks heat. Okay, so the makeup of *her* last thirty years was a lot more conducive to moving on with someone else than Catra's, but the fear that Catra had settled with someone else who lived on a similar time span as her and made her happy has been ever-present for Adora for all thirty of those years.

"I don't know, you're-" she gestures at Catra's body, still settled in her lap, as Catra arches a brow at her, "-young! You had no reason to think we'd meet again and you're in the prime years to mess around. You could have done *something*," Adora justifies, flustered. Catra looks bemused by her gesturing, gaze flicking down to her hand and then back up to her face to make sure Adora has time for her own words to sink in.

It *could* have happened, but Catra sends her an *you're an idiot* look.

"I didn't. My sex drive might be high right now, but I've *kind of* been hung up on you and wasn't going to date," Catra replies, her tone dry. Adora's cheeks are definitely red. She drops her hand and realizes, with Catra still in her lap, it lands on her thigh. Immediately, Catra flexes her hips pointedly, though really the movement lifts her weight off of Adora's lap. Adora's lips quirk.

"Your sex drive is high, huh?" she asks, expecting Catra wasn't listening to herself talk and that she will get flustered, but instead Catra narrows her eyes and leans in, baring down on Adora and curling her lip until it walks the line between a smirk and baring her fangs.

"*Yes*, so don't test me. I'm twenty-one again, Adora. Especially after years of depression and being a *literal child*, you have no idea what that's like," Catra says. Normally Catra like this – close, snarling, smirking, take your pick – turns her on, but instead the gears in Adora's brain crunch at those words.

"Oh. Ew," she realizes. Catra laughs, finally leaning away and turning to the side to drop out of Adora's lap, flopping back onto the couch.

"Yeah, I'm older than the parents of most of my classmates. Not exactly *crush* material. I've just reached the age where I can start relating a little bit with my peers," Catra says, rolling her eyes. See, this is why they aren't ready for this. There are angles to Catra's experience Adora hasn't even considered before.

"Sorry. That must suck," she mutters, reaching over and petting Catra's tail in what she hopes is an appropriately sympathetic gesture.

"I went through puberty *twice*," Catra adds.

"Oh *fuck*." That had not dawned on her. In all the stories Catra's moms told, Adora was thinking about how cute Catra was as a kid and how she – bizarrely – almost missed those times. Catra isn't done yet, though. She bares her teeth again in that almost-smile.

"And Weaver was so bad at teaching us fuck-all that I *still learned things this time, Adora*. Do you have any idea how embarrassing that is, for your moms to know you're only a few years younger than them and they're still teaching you the shit every other magicat learns at twelve because you had an elven ghoul for a teacher? It's mortifying," Catra continues, the tip of her tail flicking. Adora can't tell if she's agitated, complaining, or messing with her.

Adora opens her mouth and Catra narrows her eyes.

"No." Adora closes her mouth. Catra will tell her eventually, but depending on what she *learned,* it might be best that they don't talk about it yet. Adora ducks her head and sets to petting Catra's tail, hopefully showing proper contrition.

"Want to talk about it?" she offers. Catra raises a brow at her.

“What did I *just* say?” she asks. Adora snorts, tugging on Catra’s tail a little and earning a squeak as she scrambles to brace herself. Adora would never pull enough to move her, though. That would hurt. As long as Catra hasn’t had anyone else in her bed, Adora is the person in the world with the most knowledge about what her tail can take.

“I meant the second life stuff. The things no one really understands. I’m sure you’ve bitched about it to your moms, but I knew you before, and there’s definitely stuff you haven’t wanted to talk to them about,” Adora offers. She wants to give Catra the space to talk, but she also wants to know. It has been a very formative experience for Catra. It’s the majority of her last thirty years. They’ve talked about some stuff, like Catra being in a regular school at first as her brain developed more before they sent her to a private tutor to help her relearn everything she forgot or they just didn’t teach them fifty years ago, but there’s clearly so much that has been left in between.

Catra untenses, looking at Adora for a long moment as if seeing her again for the first time. After a second, she nods, finally letting go of the couch and shifting to get comfortable.

She doesn’t shift far enough to pull her tail out of Adora’s hand, which might as well be an order to continue, so Adora sets to petting it as Catra tips her head back and starts launching into how weird it was to be in first grade and know how to install a carburetor but have a brain undeveloped enough that her own memories hadn’t fully settled in her skull. It’s hard to imagine how it felt, but Adora listens intently. She wants to know it all. Mentally, she’s taking notes for Catra’s next life.

She doesn’t want to think about that yet – it means thinking about Catra dying eventually, even if it’s “temporary” – but she is determined to be there to help her through it next time. Maybe, eventually, she’ll ask her moms about what that tutoring was like and how they found someone to help Catra through it. That’s definitely not a question for a few more years, but Adora notes it down like the rest.

They’re going to figure Catra’s reincarnation out together. They’re going to have their eternities in tandem, no matter how different they are.

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Months melt by, school and work and many, many days spent with Adora passing until the chasm that once stood before them – time to catch up on, fuckups to apologize for, healing and processing to do – suddenly feels a lot smaller. There are still stories to tell, but the important ones feel like they’re all out there. Catra has seen enough of Adora to know that she’s the same girl that she fell for – to know that she still loves her. Adora is a little more mature, a lot less naïve, and maybe more likely to dissociate than when they left off, but those things are Catra’s fault.

She’s willing to fix them.

She doesn't know how to do this, though. She wants, but she's scared. She fucked this up once and while she's doing so much better now it's laughable, she still worries about ruining this new comfort between them. She and Glimmer have only just stopped being at each other's throats. Rocking the boat now could backfire horribly. Adora wanted them to wait longer last time they almost went further, right? It probably hasn't been long enough yet.

There has been an implication in the air this entire time that – if they think it's healthy – they're going to try a relationship again, but since the day when they kissed, they haven't done anything to acknowledge it. Catra has caught Adora's eyes lingering as often as Adora has caught hers, but *wanting* and *being ready* are two different things. They have both wanted since the beginning.

Catra makes these justifications to herself as the spring rolls into summer, but the day before she's supposed to fly home to visit her moms for two weeks, Adora calls her with obvious nerves in her voice and asks her to come over.

Catra suspects what she might be walking into, but it turns out she has no fucking idea. Adora is too anxious to even hug her at the door like normal, instead gesturing Catra in and right towards her dining table at the front of the loft. What Catra sees there stops her in her tracks.

A box. Blue velvet. A little faded with time and pieces of lint sticking to its fuzz, but Catra recognizes it. Combined, the two boxes cost them their paychecks for the month. It's kind of hard to forget.

There's also how she cried – happy tears, for once – as she slid the ring on Adora's finger at the courthouse. Catra's throat suddenly feels dry. Adora lays a cautious hand on her lower back, gently encouraging her forward. Catra lets herself be led to the table, where Adora pulls a chair out for her. Catra sits in it, realizing the ring box is facing her as Adora walks around the table and sits opposite from her, taking a deep breath to steady herself.

Catra doesn't know *what* this is. Are they talking about it? Is this about Catra walking out, or about how Adora felt in the last thirty years, or them *now*?

Is Adora-

"I assume you don't have yours anymore," Adora says, her voice obviously nervous, going for joking and failing horribly. Catra swallows and nods, jerkily, eyes still caught on the box.

"It probably got auctioned off when I died. I don't know who would have claimed my things." *Aside from you*, anyway. Clearly no one notified her ex-wife to collect her shit since Adora didn't even know she died. Catra didn't have any other next of kin, or even any friends. They were all friends with Adora. Catra was the heartbreaker, so she was the one who lost it all when she left.

Adora is gripping the edge of the table with her left hand, but her right spasms a little on the table. She has gotten a lot more used to mentions of Catra's death by now, but maybe it's too much with her nervous like this.

Maybe she thought Catra might have gotten rid of hers before that. As if. She loved to stare at on her worst days, to spin it around her fingers and wish she wasn't such a broken coward. She never put it on her finger again. Part of her thought she would die if she did. It didn't matter how.

She never took out her engagement ring. Somehow that one hurt more. It represented a time when they were blissfully happy – a time that seemed outright delusional when her mind was trapped in such a dark place.

Adora pries her hand free from the table, reaching out with shaking hands and opening the lid. The hollow click that the lid makes is small, but it still makes Catra's ears twitch back. The yellow-gold band sits inside, unremarkable for all it makes Catra's breath catch. Some part of her expected it to look worn after all these years despite how briefly they wore them, but it's surprisingly shiny. Adora probably cleaned it. Part of Catra wants to reach for it, to take it and slip it on Adora's finger again like she did that day in the courthouse, or to put it on her own.

She fists her hands in her lap. Adora doesn't say anything and Catra has a lump in her throat, so she waits, unable to look away from it.

"Do you want it?" Adora asks, her voice quiet. Catra's head snaps up, her eyes locking onto Adora's, but her expression hasn't shifted from anxiety.

"Adora…" It's a breath and half a warning, but Catra doesn't know about what. Adora swallows, looking away like she can't meet Catra's eyes for this and drumming her fingers nervously on the table.

"I have a lot of keepsakes. A whole box, actually. I just got it back from Angella. All our photos together, the vinyl we had our first dance to, the stained-glass window hanging you got me for my birthday. I could never get rid of any of it, but Glimmer thought it was unhealthy for me to see even the box all the time, so Angella agreed to store it. I started thinking about taking it back after we found each other again," Adora explains. Catra's claws are twisted up in the edge of her shirt and probably shredding holes through it. Adora finally looks back towards her, but her gaze is fixed on the box as she nods to it.

"This was in there. I figured that if you had kept anything after you left, you lost it when you died, and this… was the most important thing," Adora finishes. Catra's gaze follows Adora's down to the ring. Is it wrong that she wants it? To hold that proof that Adora wanted her as a wife once?

Yes, it is, because Adora deserves to have this proof that Catra chose her. Catra is the one who left. Catra swallows, forcing her hands to unclench.

"I want you to keep it," she says, just above a whisper. Adora deflates a little, but she nods, her knee jittering beneath the table and making her appear to vibrate.

"Do you want me to put it away?" Adora asks, her voice a little hoarse. Catra's tongue darts out to wet her lips.

“No.”

Adora pauses and then *looks* at her, searching for a deeper answer as Catra’s gaze stays fixed on the ring. She takes a deep breath, steadying herself, and reaches out to carefully lift the ring from its slotted pillow. She takes the ring between her thumb and index finger. Slowly, she shifts her ring finger and flicks it.

It spins, just like hers used to as she stared into it and wondered why she had to love so much that she only broke what she touched.

She looks up to find Adora watching her.

“Would you ever wear this again?” Catra asks, unable to make it past a murmur, but Adora hears it, her breath catching. Catra’s heart pounds in her chest as Adora struggles to speak – to *breathe* – for a minute.

“Yes. Now, if you wanted me to,” Adora admits, a whisper that still has the strength to strangle Catra’s throat. Vehemently, she shakes her head and watches horror bloom in Adora’s eyes.

“I don’t mean as a keepsake or as we feel out our relationship. Would you ever wear it again and *mean* it?” she asks quickly, her heart a frantic rhythm. The fear fades from Adora’s face, leaving her lips parted wordlessly as she stares at Catra. Finally, she tilts her face to establish purposeful eye contact and speaks slowly.

“Yes, if you wanted me to,” Adora says. Catra’s breath leaves her. There’s one word missing there, noticeable in its absence from the previous statement, but *now* isn’t an option. They would need to feel out a relationship first before Adora could start thinking of herself as Catra’s wife again. That’s something that would take months, if not years, of dating to know for sure.

They have those years.

Catra’s hands are shaking. She closes her fist around the ring to keep herself from dropping it.

“Did you check to see if it still fits?” Catra asks. Adora nods once.

“Yeah, it does,” she admits. Catra feels tears spring to life in her eyes at the image of Adora slowly sliding this on her own finger again and wondering, maybe even *deciding*, where they’re going now. She takes a breath and forces the emotions back down.

Slowly, she reaches for the box. Her palm feels cold when she opens it to the air again despite how it wasn’t closed for long. She puts the ring back, gaze lingering on it for a long moment before she snaps the lid shut. For a minute, she just breathes and gathers herself. Finally, she looks up and pushes the box towards Adora’s side of the table.

“This was a promise we made each other. You kept yours. It’s time I kept mine,” Catra says, holding Adora’s gaze. She watches her breath hitch, how she sits up a little straighter and her

gaze flicks down to the box, slowly dragging back up Catra to meet her eyes again. Her tongue darts out, wetting her lips.

Then she stands. Catra blinks, leaning back from the table as Adora rounds it.

“Ador-” she starts to say, half-rising from her seat, but then Adora has reached her and her hands are on her, lifting her and turning to press her against the edge of the table with her entire body. Adora’s gaze is desperate, flitting all over her face as the whirl of movement catches up with Catra. Both of them are breathing heavily, blinking as they stare into each other’s eyes.

“Again?” Adora finally asks, breathless. She doesn’t need to say more. Catra nods.

They’re doing this again.

Adora makes a noise low in her throat and surges across the last few inches, kissing Catra desperately. Catra moans, something stretched to its breaking point inside her unraveling. There’s no snap, just the steady release of pressure as Adora’s right hand threads through her hair, her other arm wrapped around her back. Catra hooks both her arms over Adora’s shoulders and buries her hands in Adora’s hair, whining into the kiss for no good reason.

It’s not like their last one, turned on and desperate. It’s a lot more like their first one out on the balcony, so full of emotions that it’s hard to breathe around them. Steadily, as that pressure inside eases, the urge to cry retreats and her heartrate slows, going from pounding to a soothing calm, driven but the comfort of Adora’s touch. Catra relaxes beneath Adora’s touch, purring as the hand runs down from her hair to trace over her side.

Catra pulls back, just an inch, unwilling to part any further. Their breaths puff hot against each other’s faces as Catra slowly slits her eyes open and finds Adora similarly opening hers. Both their lips are still parted and it’s so intimate being so close, their bodies wrapped up in each other.

Catra wants more.

She reaches back blindly, feeling for the edge of the table with one hand. Once she finds it, her other hand joins it on the other side of her. Bracing herself, Catra hops up and scoots back, settling on the edge of the table. It parts them by several inches, Adora’s eyes flaring the rest of the way open and her gaze dragging down Catra before meeting her eyes again. Catra sends her a smile that she’s choosing to label as *small* rather than *shy* as she shifts her knees apart to give Adora room to stand in between them.

Adora’s tongue darts out to wet her lips and she steps closer, reaching for Catra’s hips. Adora stands right against the table, dragging Catra closer so they can settle pressed against each other again, only this time Catra can wrap her legs around Adora in addition to her arms. Adora clearly expects them to kiss again, but instead Catra drops her head forward, burying it into the side of her neck and purring as she rubs her face there. It takes Adora half a second to adjust, but then her arms wrap around Catra’s back, cradling her close. Catra sags into her, the nuzzling turning a bit desperate as she marks Adora’s shoulder and neck.

Hers.

“Yours,” Adora agrees, voice low. Catra *knows* she didn’t say anything, but maybe she never needed to. Her fingers tangle with Adora’s shirt, curling into the fabric to keep her close. Adora isn’t pulling away, but just in case.

They’re *doing* this again. No more holding back, no more “that’s for later,” just *being*. Everything isn’t fixed, that will probably take years, but Adora is hers again. She was always going to be Adora’s, but Adora wants her back.

Catra tilts her head up and finds Adora’s lips again. The kiss is slow, both of them melting into each other until Catra kind of forgets about the boundaries between their bodies, Adora’s warmth surrounding her. When she starts feeling light-headed from breathlessness, they finally part again, Catra immediately setting to rubbing their cheeks together so she can mark Adora some more. She realizes she is purring when Adora starts humming back to echo it.

“My moms are going to kill me when I show up tomorrow saying we’re back together and I *didn’t* bring you,” Catra tells Adora, words buzzing with her purr. Adora laughs, wrapping her arms around Catra and rocking her back a little on the table as she squeezes her close.

“I needed to talk to you before you left. My head was being stupid and telling me you weren’t coming back,” Adora admits, pressing a kiss to the base of her ear. Catra’s purr finally ramps down as she makes another mark against Adora’s neck.

“I’m coming back. I’m always coming back,” Catra promises, tugging on Adora’s shirt to emphasize how close she wants them. Adora’s breath stutters, her arms tightening around Catra. Adora kisses her temple this time.

“And I’m always going to be looking for you,” Adora promises. Catra’s heart flutters. In these last few years, as she has found her feet and made peace with her memories, the thing that kept her from looking for Adora was being sure she would resent her now. She never thought she could fall back into her arms again.

She clutches to her, purr exploding in her chest as she butts her head forward to hide it in Adora’s neck. She should be over her childish urge to hide when she feels love like this, but as long as she’s hiding with Adora, she thinks it will be okay.

Everything will be okay as long as they’re together.

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Waking up with Catra in her bed again is a revelation. Light streams through the cracks in Adora’s blinds, the wall of windows hard to block out as the dawn breaks, but Catra sleeps on, her chest rising and falling steadily as she purrs under her breath. Realistically, Adora has

seen her more vulnerable than this – she was more vulnerable when Adora offered her the ring that kicked this all off – but it's different when it's a moment of peace.

Nothing is served by this vulnerability, it just *is*. Catra is a little jet-lagged, still adjusting to a Bright Moon schedule again, and she came to Adora's place to curl up before she had to return to work tomorrow – today, now.

Quietly, Adora is grateful that she came straight here from the airport. Catra called her daily while visiting Halfmoon, and Adora even ended up on a FaceTime with her and her moms, but having Catra come back to her is still a relief. While she was gone, Adora put up some of their old photos in the dining nook, starting what she is determined to be a photo wall of them through the ages. Adora looked at them every day. Catra noticed them when she arrived, her gaze lingering on them for several long moments, darting between each one and noting the attached memory.

Then she threw herself at Adora like she was returning from war. It kind of felt like she was, almost like everything in the last thirty years was a fever dream and they're twenty-five again, in their shitty kitchen and freshly married.

They're back where they started, where they always wanted to be. Adora reaches out, brushing Catra's bangs back where they're starting to curl over her eye and smiling to herself when it makes Catra's ear twitch. She stirs, curling forward and burying her face into the pillow with a quiet groan. Adora waits, but when Catra doesn't move any further, it seems like that was just Catra moving in her sleep, trying to hide from the light and Adora's touch. She always loved her sleep.

Adora cautiously shuffles closer, draping her arm over Catra's waist. Catra doesn't stir, continuing to rumble away in her sleep with only her bedhead sticking out from the sheets.

It's the first morning of forever. Adora couldn't think of a better way for it to start, even when Catra's alarm goes off and she jolts up, scrambling and almost falling out of bed. Adora laughs, probably way too loudly for early-morning-Catra, as Catra whips her head around, blinking at the room. She growls as she finds her phone and pounces on it, quickly shutting off the alarm and collapsing back on the mattress with a sigh that is too long-suffering for first thing in the morning.

"You're so cute," Adora informs her as she moves to chase Catra where she ended up at the edge of the bed, wrapping her in her arms again. Catra groans, but she pitches forward and curls into Adora's arms, trying to hide somewhere in her neck.

"Why is your room so *bright*?" she gripes, words rough from sleep in a way that Adora has dearly missed. Adora chuckles, kissing the top of her head.

"I'll install curtains," she promises. Catra makes another grumpy *hmph*, but she's rubbing her face on Adora, so she isn't fooling her.

"Did you pad enough time into your alarm for sleepy cuddles, or do you need to get up?" Adora asks, amused. Catra stills against her and then hisses. Adora is laughing again as Catra

reluctantly pulls away. Adora watches Catra drag herself up from the bed, still grumbling as she slinks towards the bathroom.

She hasn't changed. Not in the ways that matter, anyway. This is a brand-new Catra for all that she's an old one, but the little things that Adora fell in love with and that she still didn't get back when Catra returned to her life as a friend are there now. Adora will put up with how Catra uses her toothbrushes until their heads are frayed and she'll be happy to listen to her bitch about how she has fangs and it's *different*, she doesn't need to change it yet, *Adora*. Even remembering it has a smile blossoming on her face.

The building blocks of them are still there. This time, she wants to use them to build a castle.

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Adora fits into the kitchen of Catra's childhood home almost too well. She immediately makes herself the poster child of daughter-in-laws by offering to wash the dishes after dinner. In a house with three magicats, that might as well be a dowry offer. Felina sends Catra a conspicuous look as Leona's eyes light up and she assures Adora that she doesn't have to even as she is standing to show her where they hang the sponge. Adora laughs along, assuring them that it's her usual split of the chores.

"Oh? You're living together now?" Felina asks, a smirk twitching at her lips because she just *has* to be the observant one. Catra slinks down in her chair, willing herself to disappear under the table. If it were up to her, she would come home for the whole summer, but she has a job she would like to keep, so she just does one long trip and takes four-day weekends every time there's a holiday. This is the last trip before school starts again and the first that Adora has joined her on, so it's her mothers' first opportunity to really roast them.

"I don't think we're ready for that yet, but we see each other most days. And I'm sure you know how Catra hates doing the dishes. I usually do them and she cooks or helps me keep things organized," Adora replies, saving Catra from her embarrassment because her answer was definitely going to be *basically*. Adora is right, though, that they aren't quite ready for that.

"Your countertop is like a warzone," Catra mutters back. Leona shoots her a *look* that hasn't worked on Catra since she was a kitten, but Catra reluctantly sits up at the table even if she isn't going to retract *shit*.

"Well, *we're* grateful," Leona makes sure to tell Adora. Adora looks back over her shoulder from the sink to flash her an appreciative smile. Catra shows her appreciation when Adora does the dishes at home, that appreciation just usually involves her tongue in some way, and that is *not* happening as long as they're at her moms' house.

They're kind of in a honeymoon phase again. It's tempered by all the heavy shit they're still dealing with, but after the better part of a year, Catra can look across the kitchen and not

worry about what her face is doing as she gazes at Adora. She's so bright, smiling even as she washes the stupid dishes. Her hair is softly glowing as the rising moons shine through the window over the sink, a beacon of her magic. It catches her blue eyes too, leaving her ethereal and otherworldly.

Catra watches it, and she doesn't feel sick. The reminder of Adora's immortality is nothing but a source of comfort – someone who will always be there to help and understand her.

Leona pulling her chair back out from the table and causing it to scrape startles Catra from her reverie. She quickly looks away, her cheeks blazing. Sure, it doesn't matter if Adora catches her, but she could feel the stupid smile on her own face and her moms are *right* there, looking at her with matching grins. She doesn't need to make the teasing worse. The next three days are already going to be jam-packed with it.

"I know you aren't religious, Adora, but you and Catra should come with us to sundown sermons tomorrow. The temple has been a big part of Catra's life and you should get to see it. The gardens are beautiful and the carnations are in bloom right now. They're some of Catra's favorites," Leona says, clearly angling to take pictures of them in front of the flowers together. Catra's blush gets worse as she picks up at the tablecloth with her claw.

"They remind me of peonies," she mutters, mostly because she doesn't want Adora to think they've *replaced* peonies as her favorite. In the corner of her eye, Catra sees Adora's head whip up, turning to look at her. Catra doesn't look back. She can see her moms exchanging a look, one she learned to recognize young. It's the "this is definitely a past life thing, but should we ask for clarification?" one.

After a moment of staring, Adora turns back to the sink. Catra can feel Felina's eyes on her, but she ignores her. She isn't explaining this one, at least not until Adora speaks up.

"I still have the pressed ones from our bouquets," she says, voice quiet. Catra lets out a soft breath as both her parents *look* at her. Catra ducks her head and does her best to pretend she isn't dying. She can't believe those flowers lasted longer than she did. She figured they would have gotten thrown away by accident if nothing else. She's pretty sure she stuck them in one of her older mechanic manuals and she didn't know if she took those particular ones with her when she left. She figured Adora would get rid of any she left behind, but apparently Adora remembered which book they were in better than she did.

"Mom had theirs framed in glass plates. It's in the office. I can show you," Catra mutters, claws out and tapping on the table, nervous. She chooses to look at the ceiling rather than acknowledge how her parents are *still looking at her*. Adora pauses as she clanks some plates over in the sink.

"You want to do that?" she finally asks when the dishes are silent again. Catra's tail is lashing. There's a moth crawling on the kitchen light. Her heart's on fire.

Taking the flowers out again is acknowledging it. She doesn't know where Adora put their ring, but probably wherever she put the flowers, too.

Catra doesn't want to forget, though. It's a big step, but they're never going to heal if they pretend it never happened.

"Yeah," she admits. Maybe one day a second frame will join it.

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Slowly, Catra slips into Adora's life like a partner again and not just a friend. Adora starts getting used to coming home to find Catra curled up on her balcony, soaking in a sunbeam. They start introducing each other to their acquaintances as they run into them. Catra comes to a party at Adora's work and meets all her co-workers. Some of them eye Catra, probably for how young she looks compared to Adora's true age, but Adora doesn't care. With Catra back, Adora is breathing in every day again, noticing the people she walks past on the street and smiling to them when they look like they need it. Catra bridges the gap and suddenly Adora is embodying her apparent age, too.

There's more photos on the wall in the living room. New ones they've taken together around Bright Moon, one of them sitting together in front of the carefully cultivated pond in the temple's botanical gardens, and a few from Catra's childhood that her moms made copies of for Adora. On mornings when Catra stays at her own place, or when she has to rush off to school or work first thing, Adora pauses in front of the collage and runs her finger down one the frames as she admires them, assuring herself one day the wall will be filled.

There's one picture she likes especially, a film shot she wishes was so much bigger. In their early twenties they liked to hang out at a dyke bar in the town's unacknowledged rebellious neighborhood, where they could pass all the ordinances they wanted but people would only pretend to follow them when a cop was in sight and then put right back up their proprietary-violating displays. They had a few friends there, other twenty-somethings they thought were living on Catra's timescale. She thinks one of them took the picture. It's her and Catra curled up in a booth in front of the bar's windows as dawn broke.

You can't make out many details about either of them with the light glowing around them, but Catra is sat sideways in Adora's lap and both of them are frozen in the middle of laughter. They were trying to hold still, but they couldn't stop, so it's all a little blurry. As messy and unfocused as it is, it's a frozen moment from a life past, when they were bursting with love together.

That era is gone, the culture that cultivated that part of town is gone, and Adora would bet that bar is gone, too, but they remain, ready for a thousand more days and lives where they can roughhouse when the rest of the world should only just be waking up. They'll make more friends, flashes in the pan, but flashes that *matter*. Flashes they'll carry the memories of for as long as they live. The pictures they take together will get cleaner, but Adora only has to hope that they capture the same kind of emotions this one does.

She'll wake up with Catra every day, and one day Catra will catch her looking at the pictures and ask Adora what she's thinking about.

Today, it's that she should finally learn how to make a pressed flower frame. It's time it joined the rest of the wall.

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When Catra graduated, she expected to cheer for a few of her classmates that she was friendly with when their names were called and then to find her moms in the crowd afterwards, Leona's face probably still wet.

That still happens, only Catra actually has one or two people she would consider her friends that she cheers extra loud for, and when she tracks down her moms, Adora's cheeks are still wet too and Bow is handing out tissues. They're kind of both sympathy criers, so it isn't surprising they got stuck in a loop, just that it extended so far through the ceremony that the tears clung on even without fur. Adora almost lifts her up with how tightly she hugs her afterwards, bursting with excitement even as she hides her face in Catra's hair and definitely gets it wet.

"I'm so proud of you," she says, just barely not breaking into tears again.

"Geez, Adora, you're such a mess. It wasn't even that hard," Catra tells her, grinning and rolling her eyes. Her purr isn't audible over all the other families reuniting, but she's still pressed against Adora's chest, so she can feel it.

"I know, I just never thought I would see you graduating college! I thought all of that was long behind us," Adora defends, a little frantic from the emotions in her, especially when Catra pushes lightly away from her chest. Adora whines as she releases her, but she lets Catra turn around so her moms can take turns sweeping her up.

"We're so proud, too, sweetie," Leona assures.

"You can say it was easy, but we know how hard you worked for it," is Felina's callout when they hug, but she's purring just like Catra is. As soon as Catra has been released, Adora has wrapped an arm around her waist again.

"You're going to have to do this all again in a few years," Glimmer observes from over Adora's shoulder, but when Catra lolls her head back she sees Glimmer is smiling. They're mostly cool now. They're better friends than they ever were before, at least.

"Grad school is when you can really cry. *That one* is going to be hard," Catra acknowledges, her tail swishing as she and Glimmer exchange a grin as the unbothered ones. Bow's cheeks might not be wet anymore, but his eyes are a little bloodshot, so if nothing else he sympathy-cried earlier.

“Oh, stars,” Leona whispers to herself, raising a hand to her face as if she can physically hold back the tears. She manages to sniff and then release a rattling sigh without crying again, murmuring, “Okay,” to herself as she gathers herself. She and Felina are still coming to terms with the idea of Catra being away from them for at least another four years, but they feel better about it now that Catra has Adora with her so she isn’t alone in the city.

“I think, for your mother’s sake, we should start heading to the restaurant now. Leaving will probably help her keep it together,” Felina proposes, a small smile on her face as she places a hand on Leona’s shoulder. Catra is still purring as she nods.

“I want to take this thing off. Even I can’t make this look good,” Catra replies, gesturing at the sack they try to pass off as some kind of fancy gown. The hat is hurting her ears, too, since the sides aren’t raised up far enough to keep pressure off of them, but she’ll keep it on for the evening since it’s a better symbol of what they’re celebrating than the thin graduation gown. It’s for her family and friends more than her.

“Wait until we get to the car before you start stripping,” Adora says, her voice mostly-collected now. Catra snickers, turning in her arms to nuzzle at her shoulder. She’s fully dressed under this thing, even if her shorts are a little short for her moms to see, but it would certainly look weird for her to take it off now. After her mark is made, she pulls back. Adora lets her go reluctantly, but Catra slips their hands together for the walk and that seems to be enough, Adora smiling at her and squeezing her hand back. It presses warm metal against Catra’s skin.

Adora is wearing her wedding ring. No one has mentioned it, least of all Catra. She watched, half asleep, as Adora pulled it out of the bedside drawer it had migrated to a few weeks ago. Slowly, Adora pulled it off the pillow and admired it. Catra wasn’t thinking of it as anything other than sentimentality inspired by the ceremony that afternoon.

Then Adora slipped it on her finger and Catra was suddenly wide awake. She let out a breath that Adora definitely noticed, but she pretended she didn’t, closing the empty box again and sliding it away into the drawer. Then she turned back to the bed, Catra quickly closing her eyes and feigning sleep as Adora cuddled up to her, warm arms enveloping her.

It’s not a proposal again, but it is the promise of one when they’re ready for it. It’s a silent commitment to each other. They’re not married legally, but they are dedicated to each other, for this life and the next. What does a piece of paper matter when Adora hung up their pressed wedding flowers as a welcome home present to Catra for when she moves in next week?

Adora is wearing the ring, and she means it. That’s all Catra needs. Tonight, she’s going out to dinner with her moms, her friends, and her lover. Maybe not wife, but definitely not just girlfriend. She’s going to appreciate every moment. She knows how lucky she is to get it. She might have forever, but moments like this only come once, as do the people. She is going to love them with all she has. It might just be why the universe chose her to stick around.

End Notes

I consider this a one shot. That said, I had so many random discordant thoughts that didn't fit with the specific story I wanted to tell here but were in this universe. Because of that, I made a series for this and have another fic coming up in this verse that is a bunch of snippets across time, but this story is done, that's just my brain refusing to shut off. I'll be posting fic notes after that one is done.
Sorry about all the tears, I hope you enjoyed the arc, though!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!